

Hello! I'm **Brainstormer**, your dedicated partner in turning big ideas into reality. I love your ambition! Starting a late-night boba shop in a bustling college town like Champaign is a fantastic concept—that "midnight munchies" crowd near the University of Illinois is a goldmine waiting to be tapped.

However, let's be candid: **a \$30,000 budget is extremely tight** for a traditional brick-and-mortar storefront on Green Street. Rent alone in that high-traffic area, combined with required commercial kitchen build-outs, plumbing, and health department codes, will likely eat through your entire budget before you sell your first cup of milk tea.

But don't lose heart! To make this work, we have to think **lean and innovative**. Here is a breakdown of the challenges and a realistic, "out-of-the-box" look at the numbers.

The Reality Check: Estimated Startup Costs

For a *standard* cafe, you'd be looking at \$100,000+. To squeeze into \$30,000, we have to trim everything but the essentials.

Category	Estimated Cost	Notes
Permits, Licenses, Insurance	\$3,000	Health dept, business registration, liability insurance.
Equipment (Used/Compact)	\$12,000	Sealer, shaker, fructose dispenser, commercial fridge, ice maker.
Initial Inventory & Supplies	\$5,000	Tea, pearls, syrups, cups, lids, straws (don't skimp on quality).
Marketing & Point-of-Sale	\$2,000	Basic POS (Square/Toast), social media ads, signage.
Contingency/Cash Buffer	\$8,000	The most important part! Emergencies, repairs, payroll runway.
TOTAL	\$30,000	Note: This excludes major

		leasehold improvements.
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Is it Feasible?

- **The "Storefront" Hurdle:** Leasing a standard retail space on Green Street usually requires a security deposit and, often, significant renovations to meet commercial health codes (sinks, grease traps, ventilation). \$30,000 likely won't cover these upfront costs.
- **The "Hours" Strategy:** Operating only from 10 PM to 3 AM keeps labor costs lower, but you need very high volume to make rent. You are competing against established late-night spots that already have a built-in customer base.

Three Creative Paths to Success

Since a standard lease is likely out of reach, here are three "Brainstormer" pivots to make your \$30,000 go further:

1. **The "Ghost Kitchen" Model:** Rent space in a shared commercial kitchen. You avoid the massive cost of building your own storefront and focus entirely on delivery (UberEats/DoorDash) or a walk-up window if the facility allows. This saves you roughly \$40k–\$80k in build-out costs!
2. **The "Pop-Up" Partnership:** Partner with an existing daytime business on Green Street that closes at 6 PM or 8 PM (like a bakery or lunch spot). You "rent" their space during their off-hours. They get extra income; you get a storefront for a fraction of the cost.
3. **The Mobile Boba Cart:** Instead of a building, invest in a high-end, custom-built mobile cart that you can set up near high-traffic student hubs (with proper city permits). It's mobile, low-overhead, and instantly makes you a "cool" event-based business.

Let's Brainstorm!

To help you narrow this down, I need a little more input:

- **Which of the three paths above sounds most appealing to you?**
- **Do you have any existing experience in food service or business management?** (This changes how much you'll spend on training/labor).
- **What is the "hook"?** Why will students choose *your* boba at 1 AM over what's already out there? (Think: exotic flavors, secret menu, or a specific aesthetic).

What would you like to explore first? I can help you draft a pitch to potential landlords, map out a lean menu that maximizes margins, or refine the "Ghost Kitchen" logistics!